





There's something poetic, even vague about the word 'otherwhile', but having picked it as the title of his new exhibition at Chemould Prescott Road, Mumbai, Jitish Kallat would prefer that we didn't go looking up its meaning in a nearby dictionary. "That would dismantle the show in ways that may not be most interesting. *Otherwhile* has to do with temporality and the idea of time. Time remains a central, key theme in the exhibition, but also in my life's work." In 'Otherwhile', a photographic work on glass, we see people try to hold with their fingers the sun, that daily marker of our days. Like time, the work, too, is fragile. As you gaze harder, your perspective slips, "and the glass itself seems to strip".

Kallat's work has always had its own peculiar, beguiling range, and *Otherwhile* (on display until January 4), too, includes work that takes its inspiration from both the macroscopic and the petri dish of the micro. Take 'Epicycles', for instance. Isolating from his family in early 2020, Kallat began noticing small changes in his studio—"a crack in the wall, a fallen leaf". The artist's decision to then juxtapose pencil drawings of these with images from MoMA's 1955 *The Family of Man* exhibition seems apt, but also brilliant. Organised by photographer Edward Steichen, *The Family of Man* stressed solidarity in a world that was battered and bruised by World War II. Kallat was doing something similar.

"In 2020," says Kallat, "when we had a peculiar experience of the permeability of our bodies and the manner in which our entire species felt like it had something running through us, *The Family of Man* seemed like a productive archive to revisit. What was interesting was that only after I had made two or three of the 'Epicycles' works that I realised, rather uncannily, that the house where I was working in was completed in 1955—the same year that *The Family of Man* began to circumnavigate the globe."

KALLAT AND HIS ART ARE BOTH GOOD KEEPERS OF TIME, BUT THE HISTORIES THEY RECORD ARE ALSO OFTEN MORE PLANETARY THAN NATIONAL

He might not be predisposed to nostalgia, but one suspects that Kallat likes it when things come full circle. "I'm very interested in overlapping dates," he says. *Otherwhile*, for example, opened on December 4, the same day his solo debut show had opened at the gallery 25 years ago. But beyond biography, Kallat also seems to make sure that his work pays diligent heed to the calendar. Earlier this year, on June 2, the John Hansard Gallery in Southampton began hosting two of Kallat's exhibitions—*Covering Letter* and *Tangled Hierarchy*. "The central element here was the set of notes that Mahatma Gandhi had written on June 2, 1947, the day before the Partition of India was announced."

Though Kallat feels it is only worthwhile to look back if one does so to look ahead, there is undeniably much that the 48-year-old artist now has to look forward to. The Kiran Nadar Museum of Art is taking to this year's instalment of the Kochi Muziris Biennale both of Kallat's exhibitions that were on display at Southampton. "Both projects," he says, "are umbilically linked. *Covering Letter* is what led to *Tangled Hierarchy*. The latter is a curatorial project that has artists, scientists, cognitive scientists, neuroscientists, physicists, mathematicians, artists and archival documents, all being brought in dialogue with the five envelopes that Mahatma Gandhi handed to Lord Mountbatten on